understatement, especially considering his admission that ‘the BI had more or less cornered the freight-carrying business from Madras’.[60] If this was the case with Binnys, little needs to be said of the smaller Andrew & Frank (A. & F.) Harvey who were BI’s Agents in Tuticorin. The other Agents of BI were W. Nicol’s in Bombay, Parry’s in Cuddalore and Trivandrum, Bulloch Brothers in Rangoon, Bois Brothers and Company in Colombo, and Binny and Company in Madras. In Tuticorin, Madura and Company was BI’s Agent, a position it also held for other nearby ports such as Nagapattinam, Tondi, Pamban, and Karaikal.[61]

The Harvey Brothers

In the 1870s, two brothers from Renfrewshire, Scotland, Andrew Harvey (1850–1915) and Frank Harvey (1854–1905) arrived in India, like so many of their compatriots, in search of a fortune. If Mackinnon had big interests in the Calcutta jute mills, the Harveys had their fingers in cotton. Foraying deep into the south, the Harvey brothers saw a business opportunity in baling cotton. Acquiring a disused cotton press in Virudupatti (present-day Virudhunagar), they established A. & F. Harvey Cotton Press. They quickly became pre-eminent among Tuticorin exporters in the pressing and exporting of raw cotton. The business was so lucrative that a London office was opened soon.

By 1880, the firm A. & F. Harvey was formed, becoming the premier European firm (agency house) south of Madras. Rather than merely exporting cotton, the Harveys soon decided to establish a spinning mill. Using a turbine shipped from England, the waterfall in Papanasam was harnessed—an act of considerable enterprise. By 1885, the Tinnevelly Mills Ltd had begun to function. (A larger mill was constructed in 1908.) It was so profitable that the Coral Mills was established in Tuticorin in 1888 and the Madura Mills in Madurai in 1892. The Harvey brothers formed the Madura and Company with themselves as Managing Agents; the mills in Tuticorin and Madurai were generally known as Harvey Mills and not by their registered names. The Coral Mills expanded to double its size by the